My plan was to advance on two axes. A battalion group represented by a company would be astride the main foot track, and the rest of the force was to advance along the crest of the mountain range. The aim was to divert the attention of the Blueland by initially contacting the defenders along the main axis, carry out probing attacks there, while outflanking the enemy positions by a hook from the right. For this action, we planned to advance cross-country along the ridgeline. There was a wide river flowing all along the main track. As it was not fordable, it posed a major obstacle to any operations from the northern flank. Notwithstanding this challenge, I planned to move a small special mission force on the far bank as well. This was tasked to get behind the enemy positions. I did not know the Blueland plans, but I had carried out a detailed appreciation and analysed their likely options for defence of their assigned area, before finalizing my own plan.

As soon as I had finished my briefing, Brigadier V.P. Malhotra, the commander of the artillery brigade, whom I had never met before, came up to me, shook my hand, and introduced himself. He went on to say that he was the chief umpire for Redland, and his brief was to stay with me. I told him that he was most welcome to do so. But, as he was not acclimatized to the higher altitudes at which my HQ and the major offensive force would be operating, my advice to him was to keep to the main track, and accompany the force operating along it. However, to my surprise, he would have none of it, and insisted on going wherever I went.

We commenced the exercise and the Redland forces launched the offensive as planned. Though the sky was overcast and it became pitch dark, we did not find any problem in advancing into the Blueland territory. At about 11 p.m., when we had penetrated up to about ten to twelve kilometres, we came across the first signs of resistance from the Blueland forces. This was at a big nullah that joined the main river, making a deep gorge. This was held by Blueland, which engaged advancing elements on the main axis with heavy machine guns, small arms and intense mortar fire. I ordered Major A.N. Agashe, the commander of the force moving along the main track, to plan for the capture of that position or keep the